

THE REV. IGNATIUS P. MATERNOWSKI, OFM CONV.

*Captain, Chaplain Corps, U.S. Army — 508th Parachute Infantry Regiment, 82nd
Airborne Division*

March 28, 1912, Holyoke, Massachusetts — June 6, 1944, Gueutteville, Normandy, France



Capt. Ignatius P. Maternowski in the uniform of a U.S. Army chaplain, wearing jump wings and the twin crosses of the Chaplain Corps. (Submitted photo)

A Holyoke Son, A Franciscan Calling

Ignatius Maternowski was born on March 28, 1912, in Holyoke, Massachusetts, into a Polish immigrant family living among the city's mill tenements. He attended the parochial school at Mater Dolorosa parish, the church that anchored Holyoke's Polish community, before going on to St. Francis High School in Athol Springs, New York, a small town near Buffalo. There he met the Conventual Franciscan friars who ran the school and, impressed by their example, discerned a vocation to religious life.

Upon graduating in 1931, he entered the Order of Friars Minor Conventual and was sent to the St. Joseph Cupertino Novitiate in Ellicott City, Maryland, where he professed first vows in the summer of 1932. Recognized for his intellectual promise, Brother Ignatius continued his studies at St. Hyacinth College and Seminary in Granby, Massachusetts. Bishop Thomas O'Leary of the Diocese of Springfield ordained him to the priesthood on July 3, 1938. Father Ignatius was first assigned as a parochial vicar at Corpus Christi parish in Buffalo, New York, where he became known for his preaching, and later spent three years leading retreats and parish missions from the Friary of St. Anthony of Padua in Ellicott City.

Answering a Higher Calling

The Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941 drew the United States into a war already raging across Europe and the Pacific. As a patriot who wanted to serve his country, and as a priest who wanted to minister to the men who would fight for it, Father Maternowski sought and received his superior's permission to join the U.S. Army in 1942. He then volunteered for an assignment few chaplains chose: jump training with the paratroopers. Having earned his jump wings, he was assigned as chaplain to the 508th Parachute Infantry Regiment, the "Red Devils" of the 82nd Airborne Division.

Fellow troopers remembered him as a strong, lively man, well liked throughout the regiment. He had little patience for rough talk about the Church or the sacrament of confession, and was known to challenge offenders to a boxing match rather than let the comment pass. The 508th shipped out for Europe in late December 1943, arriving first in Ireland and then England, where the regiment spent five months training for the airborne assault that would open the invasion of Normandy.

D-Day — June 6, 1944

On the night of June 5, before the regiment boarded its C-47 transports, Father Maternowski celebrated Mass and gave general absolution to the paratroopers of the 508th. In the early hours of June 6, heavy German anti-aircraft fire scattered the formation, and Maternowski came down with a knot of troopers well off the intended drop zone, near the hamlet of Gueutteville in the commune of Picaucville, roughly five miles from Sainte-Mère-Église.

He soon found an American glider that had crashed nearby with multiple wounded aboard. Working with a medic, he gathered the wounded paratroopers and glider infantry at the hamlet's only business, a café-grocery belonging to the Thouroude family, turning it into a makeshift aid station. As casualties mounted faster than the small building could hold, Father Maternowski settled on a bold and dangerous plan: he would find the German officer in command of the village and invoke the 1929 Geneva Convention to secure a second, protected building for the American wounded.

He walked the length of the German-held street alone and unarmed, his helmet off and hanging from his belt, his chaplain's insignia and a Red Cross armband plainly visible. A German medical officer agreed to accompany him back to see the wounded for himself, and once satisfied, asked to be escorted back toward his own lines. Father Maternowski walked him partway, then turned to make his way back to the American side. Crossing the no-man's-land of the village street, he was shot in the back by a German sniper and killed — the only United States military chaplain to die on D-Day. He was 32 years old, in the fifth year of his priesthood.

His body lay in the open for three days while fighting continued around Gueutteville. On June 9, soldiers of the 90th Infantry Division recovered his remains and buried him near Utah Beach. In 1948, his remains were returned to the United States and reinterred in the Franciscan friars' plot at Mater Dolorosa Cemetery in South Hadley, Massachusetts. He was posthumously awarded the Purple Heart and was one of twenty-five Catholic chaplains to die in the Second World War. His headstone bears the epitaph "No greater love."

Remembered on Both Sides of the Atlantic

The people of Gueutteville never forgot the priest who died trying to protect their wounded neighbors and the American soldiers alike; they raised a memorial to him in the village in 2016. In October 2021, a stained-glass window depicting Father Maternowski in his Franciscan habit, with paratroopers and C-47s in the background, was installed in the 800-year-old Cauquigny Chapel near the La Fièvre bridge, about two miles from where he was killed. When the window was dedicated in June 2022, a French eyewitness who had been a teenager in Gueutteville on D-Day — the son of the café-grocery's owner — came forward with new testimony clarifying that Father Maternowski had been seeking Geneva Convention protection for an American aid station, and for the French civilians sheltering the wounded, not simply a joint hospital as long assumed.

Since 2019, the Franciscan Friars Conventual of the Our Lady of the Angels Province, with the World War II Chaplains Memorial Foundation, have been promoting Father Maternowski's cause for canonization. Commemorations continue every June on both sides of the Atlantic: in South Hadley, the American Legion and VFW hold an annual vigil at his grave, with the 80th anniversary in 2024 drawing a mayoral proclamation honoring him as "ever desirous to answer a higher calling"; in Normandy, Franciscan friars and U.S. and German chaplains gather each year at both memorial sites, and the 82nd anniversary in June 2026 drew the largest crowd yet — nearly 200 people — to a candlelight vigil at Cauquigny Chapel. That same June, Father James McCurry, who helped dedicate the Cauquigny window, brought the story home with a talk at Our Lady of the Cross Church in Holyoke, successor to Maternowski's childhood parish, Mater Dolorosa. More than eighty years on, he is remembered as a Holyoke son who gave his life protecting the wounded of

two armies — a memory carried in a Massachusetts cemetery, a Norman chapel window, an open cause for sainthood, and the words carved above him: no greater love has a man than this, that he lay down his life for his friends.

Sources

Ballway, "Holyoke's war hero," The Republican/MassLive, Jun 5 2026 · "Local priest honors Holyoke chaplain," MassLive, Jun 22 2025
Our Lady of the Angels Province, olaprovince.org, Jun 10 2026 · Gelinas, Daily Hampshire Gazette, Jun 7 2024
Weidenkopf, Catholic Answers Magazine, Jun 4 2019 · Pronechen, National Catholic Register, Nov 11 2022
The Companion (Companions of St. Anthony), Spring 2019 · American War Memorials Overseas, uswarmemorials.org
Portrait photo: submitted, Mark Wotton.